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High End Munich 2024 Postscript, Part 1: New Gear From Wilson Benesch, Rui Borges, Kronos Audio, Dual, and Silence

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Above, the Kronos Perpetual turntable. All photos in this story by Julie Mullins.

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KRONOS AUDIO

Kronos Audio designer Louis Desjardins introduced his new Kronos Perpetual turntable in Munich. The Perpetual design leverages aspects and some technologies from the flagship \$120K Kronos Discovery turntable: It uses the same counter-rotation system and the same motor system as found in the Discovery model, and the same control system for the speed control. Desjardins claims that the new Perpetual turntable achieves 90% of the performance of the Discovery at 60% of the price.

One difference is the addition of supercapacitors inside – “one for each motor bank, which has actually improved the stability even more,” Desjardins said. “They’re like two battery banks,” he noted of their supercap technology approach, adding that they are not actual batteries. “One gets charged while the other one gets used, and they switch over every 3 minutes so that you’re basically virtually disconnected from the wall,” he continued. “It’s a little bit like a battery system, but with much lower impedance and much higher power reserve.” They’re “supercharged” to the tune of 32Farads of capacitance at 20V, Desjardins noted. Their charge status can be seen on a seven-segment red LED display.

Desjardins also pointed out that Kronos was the first company in audio to deploy supercaps. The table’s Kronos Discovery RS tonearm (\$24,000) was fitted with a preproduction cartridge with a My Sonic Lab body. Phono signals were amplified by the Kronos Reference phono preamp.



Kronos also showed their new Kronos Discovery phono preamp (\$70,000), which has two power supplies and is mechanically isolated – a fully suspended design. Cool-looking function squares and rectangles light up the front display. It connects directly, Desjardins said, so no interconnects are needed. It was on demo with the Kronos Discovery turntable with the aforementioned Discovery RS arm, a multi-layer carbon fiber, unipivot design, and a ZYX Universe 3 cartridge in a sweet-sounding room with Göbel's new Divin Comtesse speakers.

With an SRP of \$70K, the flagship Discovery phono stage is intended to be an ultimate design of a traditional approach to phono preamplification, Desjardins said. It has three chassis (two power supply units, the other for signal), and it uses internal step-up transformers from the moving magnet (MM) stage to the moving coil (MC) stage. This can be bypassed when MM is needed, and your own outboard step-up transformer can also be deployed.



The phono preamp uses somewhat unusual tube types, including 6350s (not often used in audio) and GZ32 rectifier tubes. Desjardins chooses NOS black plate RCAs from the 1950s. Only one EQ curve is offered (RIAA, natch), but there's a passive, two-setting EQ modifier (neutral or high-frequency) that, according to Kronos, "can tame brightness, but doesn't mess with the mids."

Kronos turntables were seen and heard in at least three rooms at the show, such as Vivid Audio's large new Moya M1 speakers with Mola Mola amplification, in addition to the demo systems described above. The Kronos tables at the show were also equipped with the optional SCPS-D external power supply (\$20,000).

